THE FINAL COUNTDOWN

THE DISINTEGRATION OF 62 BRIGADE (18 TO 23 NOVEMBER)

With 4 Sikh LI having been abandoned to their fate, the remnants of 1 Sikh, 2 Sikh LI and 4 Garhwal Rifles had joined 13 Dogra at Senge Dzong by 9 a.m. on 18 November. The Chinese, though in a position to cut the line of communication with Dirang Dzong, had deliberately held their fire, letting some vehicles coming up towards Senge through to give 62 Brigade the impression that the door to the south was open.

With 13 Dogra having to act as a rearguard, Brigadier Hoshiar Singh realistically only had 4 Garhwal Rifles that was still fit enough to give battle to the Chinese. The plan for withdrawal was accordingly drawn up: the vehicle column under the command of Major Brahm Sat of 6 Field Regiment would move along the road to Dirang Dzong where it would report to Brigadier Gill of 4 Artillery Brigade; following in their wake would be the marching column which, after crossing Bridge 2, would split into two groups—4 Garhwal would follow the track leading to Nyukmadong village and Bridge 1, keeping the main road to their west; the rest would continue to move along the road, 2 Sikh LI leading, Brigade HQ in the middle with 1 Sikh and other minor units bringing up the rear.

This withdrawal plan of Hoshiar Singh’s was a tactical disaster. The brigade commander had put his administrative and other soft units at the vanguard of what should have been considered an advance towards Dirang Dzong rather than a withdrawal. With the Chinese on his tail from the direction of Se-la, Hoshiar told Brahm Sat to get an immediate move on. As the column of vehicles began to roll down the road, the weary men of the three infantry battalions hoisted their weapons and packs and started on the march towards Dirang Dzong.

By the time Brahm Sat’s convoy reached Bridge 2, he had had a start of almost two hours over the infantry column. Just when it seemed the column would make it to Dirang Dzong, the convoy commander saw his leading